I visited Gold on the evening of the twenty-third (handing him the revised "The Martian Way"), and Judy Merril, now divorced from Fred, was there, too.

I moaned about having to go way out to Brighton Beach to stay at the Blugermans', since the subway trip took better than an hour. Judy pointed out that she had the use of an apartment in Manhattan and

said I was welcome to the use of it along with her. I smiled uncertainly since I didn't know exactly what this would entail, and some possibilities frightened me.

I left shortly thereafter without further complaint about the subway ride, but when I got out into the street I found that Judy was right behind me. As we walked to the subway station at the corner, she renewed the invitation.

I said, in a nervous attempt at gallantry, "Of course, Judy, if I'm to spend the night with you, as a husband might do, I would expect a husband's privileges." (I guess I thought that Judy would laugh and refuse and I could go on to Brighton Beach on the macho plea that it was all or nothing.)

But Judy said, "Of course."

And I dashed down the subway steps.

This is not the kind of story I would tell, except that Judy herself told it, far and wide, with heaven only knows what interpolations, and I became the object of a certain gentle ridicule, for everyone knew my penchant for making gallant suggestions to the ladies. It was, I think, this story, as told by Judy, that produced the general feeling expressed to me by many a nubile young woman: "Oh listen, Isaac, if I said 'Yes,' you'd go right through that wall to get away." 3

There is a sequel to the story. By the time I got back to the Bluger-man apartment, I was in a deep state of worry. Everyone at the Golds' must have seen Judy leave immediately after me and they must all have come to the same conclusion. It was conceivable that the story, distorted and made worse (if that were possible), would reach Gertrude's ears and cause me infinite trouble.

Once I was at the Blugermans' therefore, I called Horace.

"Horace," I said, "I'm at my mother-in-law's."